

RESEARCH & DEVELOPMENT

Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) – Action Plan

Table of Contents

Preliminary Considerations	3
1 Sustainable promotion of careers	4
1.1 Introduction of the category of assistance professorship	4
1.2 Project development of the doctoral phase	4
2 Nurture a culture of collaboration	5
2.1 Open Research Data	5
2.2 Quality Management	6
2.3 A comprehensive notion of the research activity	7
The Matrix	7
The Indicator System	7
Closing Remarks	8

Preliminary Considerations

Zurich University of Teacher Education (Pädagogische Hochschule Zürich, PH Zurich henceforth) is a public institution of the canton of Zurich, accredited as university in 2021. It is the largest university of teacher education in Switzerland. The legal framework at cantonal level is provided by the Universities of Applied Sciences Act and the University Regulations. PH Zurich is responsible for training teachers and other professionals in the field of education. In this function, it promotes innovative research in the fields of teaching and learning, education and training, the education system and the profession, and disseminates its results widely.

PH Zurich consists of three Vice Rectorates, the Vice Rectorate for Teacher Education, the Vice Rectorate for Continuing Education and Services and the Vice Rectorate for Research and Development. Although the institutional research project management is part of the portfolio of the Vice Rectorate for Research and Development, *de facto* research projects can and are initiated in all three Vice Rectorates.

PH Zurich became a member of CoARA in June 2023 and, in consultation with the Executive Board of the University, has committed itself to the principles of the CoARA Agreement. The five goals of PH Zurich for the current strategy period (2022–2025) illustrate the institution's identification with the objectives and principles covered by the CoARA commitments.¹ Particularly in the context of Goal 4 (facilitating professional development) and Goal 5 (developing a culture of collaboration, anchoring leadership), PH Zurich has, in the last two years, given new impetus to its projects for the sustainable promotion of careers in the context of research on teacher education, while at the same time further developing its core understanding of quality (discursive, cooperative) and research transfer with a recently introduced institutional policy on open research data.

The Office of the Vice Rector for Research and Development is incorporating the concerns of the CoARA agreement into ongoing projects and plans. This goes hand in hand with the Committee on Quality Management's efforts to focus on the implementation of its quality principles. The Committee on Quality Management is a permanent body mandated by the Executive Board.

¹ A new strategic planning process began in spring 2025. The current strategic period has been extended to 2026, after which a new period will begin in 2027 and run until 2029.

1 Sustainable promotion of careers

The institution has most recently focused on two different development projects with regard to the promotion of careers: the introduction of a new type of assistant professorship and the launch of a major project to develop the doctoral phase. The project to develop the doctoral phase is still in progress.

The Office of the Vice Rector for Research and Development started the implementation of both projects under the following strategic guiding principles:

- To create career prospects and promote a diverse staff composition
- To further develop career opportunities in the field of teacher education research
- To take into account different levels of qualifications and professional and personal backgrounds
- To optimise the assessment of outputs and contributions conducive to the next career step

In particular, Commitment 1 of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment: «Recognise the diversity of contributions to and careers in research, in accordance with the needs and nature of research», resonates with the measures and projects underway in the institution to address a broad and diverse research community. These include structural changes (such as a new category of staff), but other processes which transcend the institution, such as the qualification of doctoral researchers in schools of education.

1.1 Introduction of the category of assistance professorship

The introduction of this new category of staff is the result of a process in which the community considered both the diversity of biographies of current and potential researchers and the specificities of career development in the field of teacher education. They have therefore developed a new category of staff that reflects these considerations.

The portfolio of responsibilities of assistant professors is designed to cover all areas (research and development, teaching, continuing education, service and consultancy, participation in expert groups, and administrative work) and must include research and teaching as core tasks.

Candidates for a vacant Assistant Professorship at PH Zurich will typically be younger than 50 years of age, although the *potential for development* of their institutional effectiveness in the field in question should be rated proportionally higher than biological age.

An Assistant Professorship may lead to a Professorship. The qualifications required for a subsequent appointment vary according to the subject and disciplinary context as well as the individual starting position. The existing profile and previous career of the Assistant Professor will be taken into account when defining the qualification targets. Individual qualification requirements and central performance criteria are expressed in a binding qualification agreement.

Assistant professorships are subject to interim and final evaluations. These evaluations are based on a performance portfolio compiled by the assistant professor, which is assessed on the one hand in relation to the individual binding qualification agreement, and on the other hand in relation to the guiding criterion of employability beyond PH Zurich.

In the event of a positive development, the tenure committee has the function of appointing an assistant professor to a regular professorship without a further competitive procedure. For this reason, there is *continuity* in terms of personnel in the tenure committee with the original selection committee.

1.2 Project development of the doctoral phase

PH Zurich considers the doctoral phase as an essential phase from the institutional and individual point of view and assumes its institutional responsibility (together with other universities) in the discussion around the independent right to award doctorates for this specific type of university of teacher education. The project to develop the doctoral phase covers therefore various activities to be conceptualised until the end of 2025 and implemented successively thereafter:

- The institutionalisation and coordination of activities to promote the doctorate
- The creation of framework conditions for doctoral students
- The optimisation of the assessment conditions for the promotion and support of doctoral students and the establishment of a coherent structure of offers
- The further development of a proper «academic qualification culture»
- The strengthening of the doctorate as an opportunity for internal personnel development and career promotion
- The increasing of the visibility of the university teacher education type in the qualification of early-stage academics

Milestone Year 2028: Development and improvement of the general framework conditions for the doctoral phase. Structure and implementation of the cooperative doctoral program «Educational Research in the Professional Field» (BiB) and of «Reconstructive professionalization research» (PRO2).

2 Nurture a culture of collaboration

The staff of PH Zurich cultivate an open, discursive, and vibrant university culture. They work in partnership on inter- and transdisciplinary matters and take into account the principles of PH Zurich's quality culture, which is ensured in particular by diverse forms of participation by all university members, university-wide specialist groups, overarching events and projects, and academic and social events on campus. The design of the workspaces and the digital infrastructure also enable and promote flexible collaboration.

The collaboration and interdisciplinary culture is an important pillar that paves the ground for the emergence of diverse research practices. Other values that PH Zurich pursues and has institutionalised or is in the process of institutionalising are openness and transparency.

2.1 Open Research Data

Open Science at PH Zurich follows the basic principles of openness, transparency, and reusability (see UNESCO Recommendation of Open Science: [UNESCO Recommendation on Open Science | UNESCO](#)) in all phases of education and research. PH Zurich is since 2018 a supporter of the 'Berlin Declaration on Open Access to Knowledge in the Sciences and Humanities' ([Berlin Declaration](#)). Through free access to scientific publications (Open Access) and the shared use of research data (Open Research Data) and teaching materials (Open Educational Resources), Open Science aims to make knowledge accessible within and outside the scientific community. Open Science is therefore part of contemporary research practice. At PH Zurich, Open Science is actively promoted, implemented, and continuously developed through a combination of services, instruments, and measures. As part of Open Access at PH Zurich, the library is actively involved in the implementation of the national Open Access strategy. The most important instruments include the PH Zurich repository and the institutional Open Access Fund (iOAF). In close cooperation with the Vice Rectorates, the library is continuously working to expand the OA infrastructure and the service portfolio to match the needs of lecturers and academic staff.

In addition to Open Access, which focuses primarily on access to scientific publications, Open Research Data (ORD) is another important field of Open Science. By participating in the swissuniversities PgB B5.2 Data Stewardship programme, PH Zurich is taking part in the [Swiss National Strategy Open Research Data](#) Programme. For the PH Zurich, participation in this ORD Programme means the integration of further steps towards Open Science.

At the beginning of March 2023, the PH Zurich launched the

PgB project B5.2 «Implementation of Open Research Data at PH Zurich». The project aims to further clarify disciplinary, legal, and information technology requirements for the public provision of data. The ongoing project wants to assess in an open debate with researchers at PH Zurich existing and potential practices in light of their legal and technical possibilities and challenges.

In doing so, PH Zurich aligns itself with the supporting commitments of CoARA's Agreement, in particular with the Commitment 5: «Commit resources to reforming research assessment as it is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to. (This includes resources to support the necessary infrastructure such as tools and services for the transparent collection and processing of data on research assessment practices).»

The overarching objective of the project is a consensual framework for the implementation of Open Research Data. This objective can be described as threefold:

- A clarification of the central legal, disciplinary and archival issues in dealing with the research data and metadata and its publication
- A definition of the best practices for research data management on this basis, and an integration into existing project management processes.
- A comprehensive support services in the fields of research data management and open research data with the goal, in the longer run, of contributing to improving data literacy among members of the research university community.

Various measures focusing on ORD will be developed and implemented over a time horizon of two years and beyond. (The action plan of PH Zurich for the PgB project can be found [here \(document in German\)](#)).

In May 2024, the Open Science Portal was launched at the PH Zurich in a dedicated SharePoint workspace accessible to the PH Zurich academic community and set up specifically for this purpose. Researchers can find content and information on open access, open research data and research data management in one place.

A further milestone in the progress of the project «Implementation of Open Research Data at PH Zurich» has been the recent approval through the Executive Board of an institutional Open Research Data [Policy](#) (May 2024). In order to meet the discipline-specific needs and challenges and to strengthen the sustainable and transparent dissemination of knowledge, the ORD policy of PH Zurich shows various rec-

ommendations in which research data can be published as ORD. The ORD policy is intended to highlight the central guidelines and further information on ORD topics will be developed and made available in the form of guidelines for researchers on the Open Science Portal (as planned as a further measure of the PgB project B5.2 Data Stewardship).

PH Zurich has developed, in cooperation with other universities, a series of modules on ORD and on research data management topics, which they offer once every semester. Work is underway on both an information sheet on data management and an internal data management plan.

Milestone year 2028: At the institutional level, the establishment of the ORD policy, the development of practical tools, and the regular implementation and communication of Open Research, which are practices key to fostering sustainable awareness and enabling a long-term cultural shift by 2028.

2.2 Quality Management

PH Zurich signed the Declaration on Research Assessment in May 2019 and cultivates an understanding of quality that is consistent with the principles of the [San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment](#), DORA, and the commitments of CoARA. The Office of the Vice Rector for Research and Development propagates a definition of quality that goes far beyond measurement approaches and attaches central importance to discursive, participatory, and dynamic notions of quality.

Particularly the Commitment 2 of the CoARA Agreement resonates through our «Quality Management Research and Development» concept: «Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators».

The «Quality Management Research and Development» concept was developed in accordance with PH Zurich's general quality framework for the current strategic period, which was meant to end in 2025 and has been extended to 2026 following the recent appointment of our new President. It adapts the quality principles of the general framework and identifies measures, activities and tools within the quality management system.

The quality culture of PH Zurich is the result of four principles:

Principle 1: a combination of individual and shared responsibility for quality

Principle 2: an open discourse on quality issues

Principle 3: the multiple perspectives of stakeholder groups

Principle 4: the preservation of the greatest possible freedom for innovation

Principle 5: a dialogue with recurring quality control mechanisms (feedback loops)

Under Principle 1, several institutionalised discussion groups and participatory instruments and activities ensure a differentiated understanding of quality. The research programmes, in which the *research units* set out their intended research agenda for the next four years, are an instrument that serves several purposes at once.

- Orientation: They provide information on the content and thematic orientation and disciplinary references of the research units.
- Planning: They show which topics the units intend to work on, or which objectives will be pursued with which resources over a four-year period. Although quantifiable objectives are not necessarily excluded, the focus is on how a research unit can develop its preferred scientific and professional themes in qualitative terms.
- Communication: They support the exchange of information within the research unit, the Vice Rectorate and PH Zurich.
- Coordination: They support the researchers within a research unit in coordinating their R&D topics and activities.
- Quality Development: The research programme has both an evaluative and a forward-looking formative character. The research programmes support the research unit in assessing the extent to which the developments and objectives have been achieved over the last four years and what further developments should be aimed for.

Quality development does not only take place at the level of the research units. At management level, quality standards are set according to the principles described above. The current four-year strategic period is coming to an end. Towards the end of the four-year strategic period, the Vice Rector for Research and Development will prepare a short self-assessment report on the state of development.

This self-assessment report will be critically discussed by the members of the Vice Rectorate and adjusted by the Vice-Rectors's Board on the basis of the discussion. This internal view of the developments will be complemented by a critical external perspective of the Research Advisory Board, whose tasks include supporting quality development and assurance. Further external and collegial criticism of individual quality-relevant aspects takes place via the annual institutional *peer feedback* with the universities of teacher education in Bern, Lucerne, and St. Gallen. Within the framework of this, peer feedback quality officers for R&D at the aforementioned universities of teacher education meet to discuss various topics relevant to the quality of R&D. The aim is to use the discussions on the further development of quality in R&D at the individual universities of teacher education.

Milestone 2028: Renewal of the institutional Accreditation according to the standards set by the Swiss Accreditation Council.

2.3 A comprehensive notion of the research activity

The Matrix

The matrix: «What research does»² attempts to capture the complexity of the research activity, by systemically classifying all related, central, and subsidiary activities and achievements, with regard to four main core tasks and four spheres of influence.

The four main core tasks are:

- Generating new scientific knowledge
- Communicating and transferring generated knowledge
- Establishing and maintaining knowledge exchange structures
- Promoting early careers

And the spheres of influence:

- The scientific community
- The institutional community
- The school and education system
- The general public

The matrix is the result of a discursive process with participation of those being assessed and an inbuilt external validation through stakeholders and groups of interest. It is an institutional framework meant to guarantee the quality assurance and continuous development of PH Zurich research output and processes, that may be used by researchers and other assessed actors to reflect their own position.

The Matrix resonates with CoARA's step 5 of the Reform Journey («develop existing and design new assessment criteria, tools and processes with the assessors and those who are assessed to include diverse practices, outputs, activities and actors»).

The Indicator System

The so-called indicator system emerged out of a project which started in the year 2019 and has received a new impulse through a new overarching project, which aims at developing an information management tool for reporting purposes in project and publications management.

The indicator system constitutes, together with the process and project management, an overarching quality management element. The system helps managers to achieve the university's goals and to base their decisions on an objective basis.

It is an organised set of management-relevant indicators that are interrelated.

There are, broadly speaking, two types of indicator systems. *Calculation* systems relate indicators to each other mathematically. *Classification* systems assign indicators to specific topics or areas of an organisation and use their structure to clarify important dependencies and relationships. The indicator system of the PH Zurich is a classification system. *Quantitative* and *qualitative* indicators are part of it.

The indicator system satisfies the specific information needs of institutional and external stakeholders and is used to evaluate the effect of all PH Zurich activities, independently of the addressee or the agent.

The performance indicators are organised according to various criteria, one of them being the indicator group, a common impact model based on the classic New Public Management model. A distinction is made between five phases:

- context
- input, the quantity and the quality of the available resources
- process, with a focus on efficiency
- output, the quantity and the quality of the immediate results
- effect and long-run impact

The indicator system is used across the institution, not only in the research and development resort. Across the board the system is conceived in a multidimensional way. For the activities in Research and Development, this has the consequence that not only are the activities evaluated, as output or product, but the context in which the activities emerge, the foundations on which they rely, and the anchoring and transfer of R&D findings are also the object of the indicator system.

The indicator system is systematically reviewed every four years, and adjusted where necessary, together with the other quality management tools. The last review took place in autumn 2024.

² This matrix was presented as a systematic to reflect the diversity of academic achievements linked to the research, with the goal of contributing towards an institutional discursive understanding of research. See Sarah Tresch und Peter Tremp, ««Was Forschung leistet»: Diskursive Verständigung und Vergewisserung dank ordnender Systematik», *Forschung (Fo)*, 2018, 1, pages 23–27.

Closing Remarks

PH Zurich has demonstrated its commitment to the principles of the CoARA Agreement by implementing several concrete projects over the past two years of the current strategic period, as well as continuously developing its quality management system. Two development projects focusing on career assessment and development have already resulted in structural adaptations, such as the introduction of a category of assistant professorship. The institution considers the development of the doctoral phase (in accordance with the CoARA principles) to be a key project, not only for PH Zurich, but for universities of teacher education as a whole. The project will continue into the next strategic period.

The process of implementing an institutional culture of open research data is underway and has reached several important milestones recently, such as the approval of an open research data policy. Further information on ORD is being developed in the form of guidelines for researchers. In parallel, our Open Science Portal is becoming better known by members of our community. These processes emerge from an institutional understanding of quality and quality management, which takes place at different levels: at the level of the research units and at management level. This understanding conceives of performance as a process that evolves and unfolds over five phases and through various spheres of influence.

The next two years will bring about the end of the current strategic period and the beginning of a new one. The new strategic period and the institutional reaccreditation process, due to finish in 2028, are further milestones in the development of our quality management system.

While the basic understanding of the concept of quality and evaluation of our research remains constant, certain tools or concepts will get revisited and reformulated. All the developments to date rely on a broad consensus about the interdependence and mutual fertilisation of the activities of the University of Teacher Education across its divisions and its members.

Providing all members of the community with opportunities for professional development implies further articulating and concretising the cooperation across the three vice-rectorates of teacher education, further education and service and research, since research activities take place not only in the vice-rectorate for research and development, but across the whole institution.

It is at this crossroad between scientific discourse and school reality that PH Zurich shapes its identity.

PH Zurich is committed to continuing its active participation in CoARA membership activities, particularly in the context of teacher education universities, and to fostering the exchange of information on hurdles and best practices in research assessment.